Interview prep: The Nature Gap report

Chief Program Officer × [redacted] · Mountain West News Bureau and KUNR Public Radio · 2026

> **About this sample.** I write a brief like this before every interview I place. This one prepared Justice Outside's Chief Program Officer, a co-author of the Nature Gap report, for a regional public radio interview. The reporter's name is redacted and the brief is excerpted for length. The story aired on Mountain West public radio stations in March 2026.

Know your reporter

Reporter	[redacted]
Title	Senior Correspondent
Outlets	Mountain West News Bureau (written) and KUNR Public Radio (audio)
Beat	Water, environment, and environmental justice across the Mountain West. Known for acequia coverage.
Interview angle	National findings through a Mountain West lens, anchored by CESOSS and acequia communities

He's a senior correspondent covering water and environment across the Mountain West, with significant reporting on acequia communities, the centuries-old water governance systems central to the report's CESOSS profile. He already understands traditional land and water stewardship, community-led conservation, and the pressures drought and climate change are putting on Indigenous and Latino communities in the region.

He responded to the pitch because the CESOSS angle connected to reporting he's already invested in. He will likely come in knowing more about acequia systems than the average journalist. Lean into that. Treat him as a thought partner and skip the primer.

> **Format note.** This runs as a written piece and as public radio audio, so think about both. Expect interest in narrative moments and community voices. If he asks for a "quick version" of something, he's looking for the radio cut.

The numbers to know

THE NATIONAL PICTURE

- Communities of color are **3x more likely** to live in nature-deprived areas.
- **74%** of people in nature-deprived areas are communities of color.
- **83%** of nature-deprived areas are renter-majority communities.
- Communities closest to pollution sources are **nearly 2x as likely** to also be nature deprived.

THE MOUNTAIN WEST ANGLE

- **72%** of Albuquerque communities are nature deprived.
- In New Mexico, **nearly half** of those living near areas with concentrated oil and gas wells are Latino.
- In Montana and South Dakota, communities near the highest concentration of pollution sources are **2.5x more likely** to also be nature deprived. It is the strongest regional compounding stat in the report.

Watch for this. New Mexico's statewide figure for communities of color (49%) is below the national average (74%). If he pushes on that, redirect to the local stat that matters most: 72% of Albuquerque communities are nature deprived. That's the number that lands.

The grantee: Center for Social Sustainable Systems (CESOSS)

- **Based in:** Albuquerque's South Valley, New Mexico
- **What they do:** Protect and revitalize centuries-old acequia water traditions while building community leadership and environmental stewardship in one of New Mexico's most historically underserved communities
- **How they do it:** Coordinating acequia associations, leading community limpias, rebuilding irrigation corridors through the Pajarito Landmarks and Acequia Trails projects, and running the Ciclos de la Tierra curriculum, which blends Traditional Ecological Knowledge with science-based restoration
- **Why they matter:** One of 11 community organizations the report profiles as closing the nature gap from the ground up
- **Connection to his beat:** He has reported on acequia communities and drought. CESOSS is the on-the-ground version of what his reporting has been pointing toward, now with national data behind it.

Interview flow: speaking points

Three of eight speaking points shown.

1. OPEN: WHAT IS THIS REPORT AND WHY DOES IT MATTER?

> *The Nature Gap is one of the most comprehensive analyses ever done of who has access to nature in this country and who doesn't. And what makes this new report different is that for the first time, we've connected nature deprivation directly to pollution exposure and climate risk at a national scale. So this is bigger than parks. We're talking about the natural infrastructure that protects people from heat, drought, flooding, and toxic air. And when you look at the Mountain West, that story gets very specific very fast.*

4. BRING IT TO THE MOUNTAIN WEST

> *When you look at the Mountain West through this data, you see patterns that your own reporting has been tracking: water scarcity, drought, communities whose access to natural resources is tied directly to their cultural and economic survival. The acequia communities in New Mexico's South Valley are a perfect example. These are communities managing water in ways that have sustained ecosystems for centuries. And the Nature Gap data shows that communities like these, where nature stewardship is both cultural practice and survival strategy, are often the ones that have faced the most disinvestment. In Albuquerque specifically, 72 percent of communities are nature deprived.*

5. CESOSS: THE SOLUTION ON THE GROUND

> *One of the eleven organizations we profile in the report is CESOSS, the Center for Social Sustainable Systems, based in Albuquerque's South Valley. They're protecting centuries-old acequia water traditions in a community that has historically been overlooked by mainstream conservation. What makes them powerful is that they are rooted in the community they serve. The report frames it well: safeguarding land and water, for CESOSS, is a continuation of ancestral responsibility. That's what community-led solutions look like, and that's what this report argues we need to invest in.*

Anticipated questions

Three of six shown.

Q: Acequia communities are already doing conservation work. Does the Nature Gap framing impose an outside definition of "nature deprivation" onto them?

That's the right tension to name. The report defines nature deprivation more broadly than "not enough parks." It measures access to natural land cover, green space, and environmental quality. Communities like the South Valley have deep ecological knowledge, and they also face real pressures from drought, disinvestment, and urban encroachment. CESOSS is profiled in this report because they represent a different model, one where the community defines what nature stewardship looks like. The report is meant to resource and validate that approach.

Q: New Mexico's communities of color number seems lower than the national average. Does the data actually show a problem there?

The statewide number is 49 percent, which is below the national average of 74. But statewide averages can mask what's happening at the local level. In Albuquerque specifically, 72 percent of communities are nature deprived. And when you layer in the oil and gas data, the compounding effect is very clear. The report is designed to be used at the local level.

Q: Justice Outside is based in Oakland. Why should a Mountain West audience care?

Justice Outside is a national organization. We fund community organizations across the country, including the Mountain West. CESOSS is our grantee partner, and they are embedded in Albuquerque's South Valley. The report is national research, co-authored with the Center for American Progress and Conservation Science Partners, with data you can localize to any state. This is us investing in the organizations that are already there and making their work visible at a national scale.

Interview reminders

- **Lead with Albuquerque.** He responded to the acequia angle. The 72% stat is your sharpest local opener.
- **Name CESOSS early and often.** It's the regional hook. Offer the direct introduction.
- **The Montana and South Dakota stat is radio-ready.** 2.5x more likely is easy to say and easy to hear.
- **Don't over-hedge on policy.** He covers environmental justice. You can name disinvestment and extractive land use directly.
- **If you don't know:** "That's a great question. Let me have Bren follow up with the most precise number on that."

SOUND BITE FOR RADIO

"What this report shows is that nature loss in this country is not random. It follows the same map as pollution, as drought, as every other form of environmental injustice. In Albuquerque, 72 percent of communities are nature deprived. The communities bearing the greatest burden are also the ones building the most powerful solutions. CESOSS in Albuquerque's South Valley is one of them."
